

The March Across the Belts

When the Swedish Army Surprised the Danes by Walking Across the Frozen Sea



Charles X Gustav of Sweden and his army on the ice after the battle of Iversnæs, by Johan Philip Lemke. Credit: Public domain / Wikimedia Commons

In war, ice is often treacherous, as the Dutch learned when French cavalry seized a fleet by riding over the frozen Niewediep canal. Or the Teutonic knights who sank into Lake Peipus while attacking Alexander Nevsky across its frozen surface. Or the Dutch, from whom the Spanish tercios escaped at night—despite being surrounded on the dike of Empel—by taking advantage of the

frozen waters. There are several historical episodes of this kind, some more steeped in legend than reality (like Napoleon allegedly bombarding the ice of the Satschen marshes at Austerlitz), and one of the most notable was the *March Across the Belts*, in which the Swedish army surprised and defeated the Danes.

This episode, known in Swedish as *Tåget över Bält*, took place during the war between Sweden and Denmark-Norway from 1657 to 1658, a conflict that overlapped with another one—the so-called Northern War—fought between the Swedes and the Polish–Lithuanian Commonwealth, with both sides backed by allies since 1655. This latter conflict had an economic motivation, with Sweden undergoing a commercial expansion in the Baltic, but also a political one, as Swedish King Charles X Gustav wanted to halt the aspirations of Polish-Lithuanian John II Casimir Vasa to the Scandinavian throne.

The far superior Scandinavian force initially prevailed and even conquered Warsaw, but then stalled against enemy guerrillas, and due to this unexpected weakness, other states joined the war. Among them was Denmark-Norway, a union of both kingdoms—plus the duchies of Schleswig and Holstein—formed in 1537, whose monarch, Frederick III, saw in the new alliance an opportunity to recover the provinces his powerful neighbor had

forced him to cede by the Treaty of Brömsebro in 1645: Gotland, Saaremaa, Jämtland, and Härjedalen.



Charles X Gustav portrayed by Sébastien Bourdon. Credit: [Public domain / Wikimedia Commons](#)

Thus, in June 1657, he declared war on Sweden, hoping it would be unable to respond while bogged down in Poland. But Charles X Gustav had a different view; he too saw an opportunity—one to deter others from joining the conflict in support of the Poles.

To achieve this, he needed a swift victory over the Danes, so he mobilized an army that crossed Pomerania with the mission of seizing Denmark, starting with the Jutland Peninsula. The force consisted of seventeen thousand men, mostly mercenaries, who swept through the enemy, forcing them to entrench in the fortress of Frederiksodde.

Although the Danes considered it impregnable, it fell in late October, along with its garrison—which included some of the best regiments—and numerous commanders. That disaster opened the door for the Swedes to take control of the islands between Jutland and Scania, which in turn provided the perfect springboard for an assault on Copenhagen. Accordingly, Charles X Gustav expected the enemy to try to block his control by any means, likely with a landing of reinforcement troops. This had to be prevented at all costs.

At first, the most suitable target seemed to be the island of Funen, so the Swedes decided to preemptively send a squadron of five

ships to transport their infantry and cavalry there. However, it was already mid-winter and also during what is now known as the Little Ice Age, which began in the 14th century and lasted until the 19th, with its coldest period from 1645 to 1715, coinciding with the disappearance of sunspots known as the Maunder Minimum. As a result, the waters of the *Lillebælt* (Little Belt) froze, preventing ships from approaching the shore.



Anonymous portrait of Frederick III of Denmark. Credit: [Public domain / Wikimedia Commons](#)

Little Belt is the name of the westernmost of the three Danish straits, the one that separates Funen from Jutland, connecting the Kattegat port with the Baltic Sea. It is about fifty kilometers long, with a width ranging from eight hundred meters to thirty kilometers.

Its maximum depth of eighty-one meters exceeds that of its sibling, the *Storebælt* (Great Belt), located between the islands of Zealand and Funen, but that was not a problem, since under the circumstances, a landing would have to be abandoned; the Swedish soldiers and horsemen—with their horses—would have to make the journey on foot, marching over the ice.

The only thing needed was to find the right place to cross, since in many areas the ice sheet was not thick enough. While scouts combed the region in search of such a spot, the cavalry gathered at Hejls under the command of Marshal Carl Gustaf Wrangel, victor at Frederiksodde, who was joined by the king himself in late January. That very day, they began their advance toward Iversnæs, one of the locations deemed to have sufficiently thick ice. Even so, sappers were sent ahead to build bridges, and it was decided to cross with the squadrons dispersed, so as not to weaken it.

The army was made up of four dozen regiments—including the Royal Guard—although many were depleted due to combat casualties and disease. Opposing them, the Danes had barely five thousand men, three thousand of them cavalry, poorly equipped, lacking experienced officers, and very short on supplies due to the loss of Frederiksdodde. This forced the troops to stay with local residents in their homes, leaving them scattered. Furthermore, there was no forage for the horses—many of which died of hunger—and the commanding general, Ulrik Christian Gyldenløve, was ill, so his aide, Jens von Løwenklau, took his place.



The March across the Belts and the occupation of the islands of Funen, Lolland, and Zealand. Credit: Alexander Alejandro / Wikimedia Commons

The bells sounded the alarm when the Swedish sappers were spotted. They had advanced ahead and wore straw in their hats to recognize one another. Wrangel, leading the right wing, crossed the ice first while the king covered the rear with the left. A regiment of Danish cavalry moved to intercept the first group but was completely routed. The rest positioned themselves in front of the beach, around their meager infantry and artillery, awaiting the imminent enemy charge. Wrangel circled around through a grove and attacked them from behind, just as the ice nearly got the better of the monarch.

Indeed, it broke under the weight of his sleigh, swallowing it along with two squadrons of horsemen; fortunately for him, Charles X Gustav had dismounted to lead the crossing on horseback. The incident did not go unnoticed by Danish General von Ahlefeldt, who ordered the cannons to fire in that direction. The king sustained a minor eye injury from ice shards but was able to continue and, seeing that Wrangel was already engaged in battle, sent reinforcements. Thanks to this, the Danish defensive line soon gave way and was forced to surrender. Swedish casualties were few, mostly due to the collapse of the ice platform.

Thus, the Scandinavian army was able to deploy its forces on Funen, occupying the island. The Danish soldiers surrendered or

fled to Zealand, sometimes after looting the peasants; others simply returned home, abandoning their weapons. General Gyldenløve was taken prisoner in Odense along with his general staff. Next to fall was the city of Nyborg, where other commanders had taken refuge, and even part of the Danish government ended up captured or released on parole. At Hindsgavl Castle, half a thousand German mercenaries surrendered and joined the Swedish ranks.



March across the Great Belt, by Johann Philip Lemke. Credit: [Public domain / Wikimedia Commons](#)

The invaders were taking control of the cities one after another, often without facing resistance: Middlefart, Assens, Svendborg... The only serious opposition came from a flotilla of four ships immobilized by the ice, which, under the command of Vice Admiral Peter Bredal, refused to surrender and engaged in a gunfight with the Swedish ships and artillery (whose firepower had increased thanks to support from land after capturing the sixty cannons of Hindsgavl). The unusual battle ended when the Danes managed to saw through the ice that was holding them and escape to Copenhagen.

Charles X Gustav sent messengers to his country announcing that great victory, achieved in just two days, aware that the news would immediately spread throughout Europe. And so it did, reaching the Danish capital and causing understandable consternation. The English ambassador, Philip Meadows, began mediating peace, since the conflict was negatively affecting trade in the Baltic and he feared that the great powers might be drawn into the war, escalating it into a full-scale conflict.

Meanwhile, the Swedes were taking pleasure in the loot obtained across multiple areas (territorial, monetary, livestock...) and continued inspecting the ice over the Belts, because their campaign was not over: the next targets were Lolland and

Zealand. However, the reports were inconclusive, and they had to wait until early February, when military engineer Erik Dahlbergh personally verified that it would be possible to cross via the intermediate island of Langeland. The problem was that the weather was highly changeable, and what worked one day might not be feasible the next.



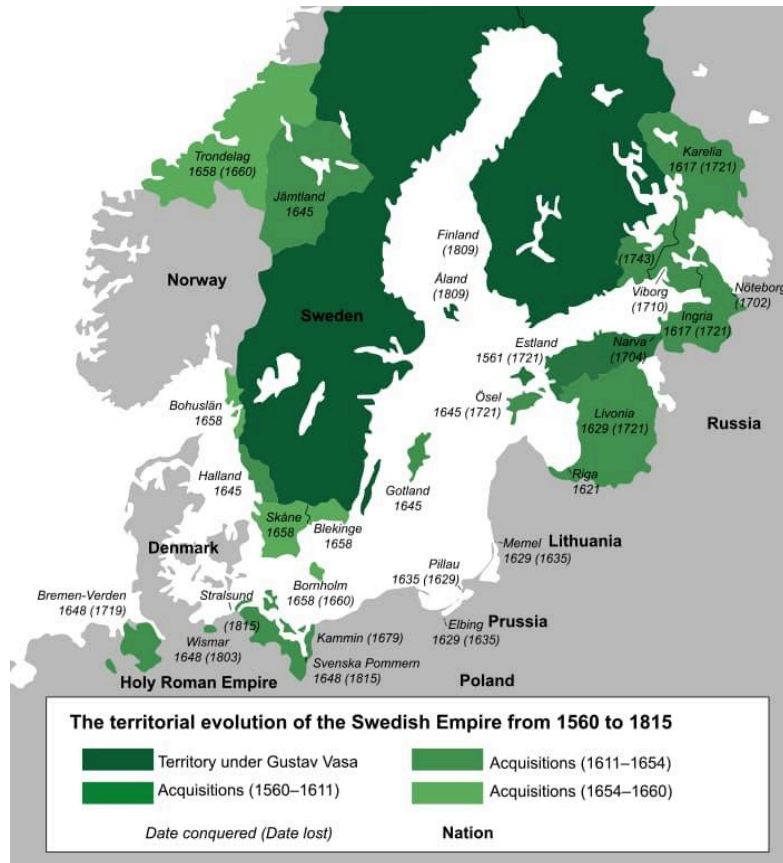
The Siege of Copenhagen, by Frederik Christian Lund. Credit: [Public domain / Wikimedia Commons](#)

It was the king who made the decision to take the risk, immediately setting out at the head of the cavalry and leaving the infantry in Nyborg under Wrangel's command. Between two and

three thousand horsemen, plus an infantry regiment, crossed through Svendborg during the night. Just in time, since the ice was beginning to melt and they had to make the crossing with water covering the horses' legs.

The Danes were forced to hastily assemble a militia of fifteen hundred peasants in Nakskov to try to stop them, but the city's burghers realized the futility of the effort and not only sabotaged the cannons but also opened the gates to the Swedes.

The Scandinavian army reached the island of Falster, where Wrangel's forces joined them after a few days, bringing the total to five thousand horsemen, twenty-five hundred infantry, and about twenty cannons. They continued their unstoppable advance toward Zealand, taking every town they came across, and four days later they arrived at Torslunda Magle, only twenty-two kilometers from Copenhagen. In the capital, they were awaited by fifty-two hundred cavalry and infantry soldiers, plus two thousand sailors and three thousand armed citizens—numerically superior, then, but severely lacking in morale.



Territorial evolution of the Swedish Empire. Credit: [Charles \(Chhrls\) / Memnon335bc / Wikimedia Commons](#)

There was no actual battle. Meadows informed Charles X Gustav that Frederick III was willing to negotiate unconditionally, and since it was also in his interest to avoid prolonging the conflict, arms gave way to diplomacy. The result was the signing on March 28 of the Treaty of Roskilde, by which Denmark ceded five more provinces to Sweden and renounced its claims over Halland, in addition to agreeing to withdraw from any anti-Swedish alliances, pay compensation, and provide troops and ships to the Swedes in case of war against third parties.